Mystery of Twicknam Vicarage

By David Ives

*In the dark before curtain: A grandfather clock chimes seven times. Then we hear three pistol shots. A woman (**SARAH**) screams. Lights come up on **JEREMY** THUMPINGTON-FFFIENES-that's pronounced "FuhFuh-Fines" lying dead on a rug at center with a glass in his hand. INSPECTOR **DEXTER:**, in a trench coat, is kneeling over the body. Around them are **MONA** THUMPINGTON-FFFIENES, the REV. **ROGER** PENWORTHY-PILKS, **SARAH** PENWORTHYPILKS, and a couch. "Masterpiece Theatre" accents.*

SARAH: Good Lord. Is he . . . ? Is he . . . ? Is he . . . ?

DEXTER: Dead? Yes, 'e's dead. Mr. Jeremy Thumpington--Fuh-Fuh-Fines 'as been shot three times through the heart. Probably within this very room, probably on this very carpet. Very nice carpet, by the way.

SARAH: Thank you, Inspector.

ROGER: (very plummy accent) I'm syorry, Inspyector Dexter. Did you say Jeremy is . . . Jeremy is . . . Jeremy is dyead?

DEXTER: 'is ventricles 'ave been completely ventilated, sir.

MONA: And yet such a brief short while ago Jerry was so alive. He was so terribly, terribly alive.

SARAH: Certainly changes our dinner plans.

ROGER: (pronounces "shooting" to rhyme with 'Jooting") This was a shuuting ekcident, Inspector Dexter?

DEXTER: A what?

ROGER: I presume a shuuting ekcident.

DEXTER: Oh, "shuuting ekcident." No, Rector, this was no mere shuuting ekcident.

SARAH: But you don't mean that it was. . . ? It was. . . ? It was... ?

DEXTER: Murder?

SARAH: Muhdeh?

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DEXTER: Yes. It was murder.

ROGER, SARAH, MONA: [Sharp, horrified intake if breath.]

INTRODUCTION

It started off quite innocently enough: Two couples meet for a quiet dinner in the home of the Revered Penworthy-Pilks . . . .Three shots are fired, three bullets hit their mark. Three suspects, three motives and one rather lifeless victim. It's interrogation time as Inspector Dexter investigates the Murder at Twicknam Vicarage by David Ives

DEXTER: Yes. It was murder.

ROGER, SARAH, MONA: [Sharp, horrified intake if breath.]

DEXTER: And I believe it was somebody in this very room who murdered him.

ROGER, SARAH, MONA: [Sharp, horrified intake if breath.]

DEXTER: I think that's enough of that. Was it you who killed him, Reverend Roger Penworthy-Pilks, the Rector of Twicknam?

ROGER: I? How dyare you insinuate such a thing! You might say I . . . I . . . I loved the man, dyemmit, in some. . . squishy way.

DEXTER: Was it you who killed him, Mrs. Reverend Sarah Penworthy-Pilks?

SARAH: It was not I, for your information, Inspector Dexter.

DEXTER: You're quite a cool, as the Americans say, cucumber. Or did you, the man's own wife, do it, Mona ThumpingtonFuh- Fuh- Fuh- Fuh- Fines?

MONA: Only two "Fuhs" in "Fuh-Fuh-Fines."

DEXTER: Sorry.

MONA: (immediately hysterical) No, I didn't kill him! I swear it! Yes, yes, I wanted him dead sometimes. I planned to murder him every now and again, often on Tuesdays for some reason. I even bought a rare Pakistani poison and a set of pinking shears that might've seemed an accident. But no I didn't kill him! I'm innocent! I swear it by all that's holy!

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DEXTER: Protesting a bit much, if you ask me. Well, one of you did it and I'm going to find out who.

MONA: I always envied you, Sarah. I confess it. Your beauty. Your coolness. Your beautiful bottom. Your thrilling long, long legs. Your beautiful bottom. Did I say beautiful bottom already? Your Wedgwood. Your tea cozies.

SARAH: And my husband. And your husband.

MONA: You slept with him, didn't you?

SARAH: Only once, but it wasn't successful!

MONA: I was speaking to Roger, thank you

SARAH:. You slept with Jeremy didn't you?

ROGER: Only twice, and it wasn't. . . very successful.

SARAH: Well I've slept with you twice and I can believe that. And I slept with Jeremy three times and we were very successful.

ROGER: Viper.

SARAH: Amphibian. [They stick their tongues out at each other.]

DEXTER: Rector.

ROGER: Inspector?

DEXTER: Jeremy Thumpington-Fuh-Fuh-Fines was quite sexually active, was he not?

ROGER: Inspector, the man was insatiable. I once came in here and thought he was sleeping on the sofa-actually he was sleeping with the sofa. The liaison went on for some months, until he chucked the sofa for my green leather wingchair.

DEXTER: You're not suggesting the sofa might've shot him--?

ROGER: I suggest you question the sofa. Maybe then you'll find the trooth. ..

DEXTER: The what?

ROGER: The trooth. You know. The fyects.

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DEXTER: Ah, the "fyects." Yes, I demand the fyects about what happened here tonight!

MONA: Oh, who cares who killed Jerry! He's dead, isn't he? That's all that's important, isn't it? That he's gone to glory? Passed over? Gone west? Put out to sea? Kicked the bucket? Cashed in, popped off, pegged out, curled up his toes, slipped his cable, croaked on this beautiful carpet during cocktails? isn't what what's important? Well. . . Not under the circumstances, I suppose. . .

DEXTER: Rector.

ROGER: Yes, Inspector.

DEXTER: Was there any tension in the room prior to Mr. Thumpington-Fuh-Fuh-Fines's death?

ROGER: Tension? Was there tension, darling?

SARAH: Tension?

ROGER: Let me think backwards. . .

*Lights change as **ROGER**, **SARAH**, and **MONA** walk backwards as if into flashback. **JEREMY:** springs to his feet, drinks glass in hand. He's got three bright red bullet holes in his shirtfront. Inspector Dexter remains, and observes.*

JEREMY: (wobbling drunk) Well isn't this is a bloody boring party.

MONA: I hope you made the cheese things. I do love the cheese things.

ROGER: The cheese things are scrumptious, are they not.

SARAH: Have we all seen 'Prime Suspect 15?

MONA: It's not nearly as good as '12'.

JEREMY: Bollocks. My God, we're not going to sit about and make bloody small talk all evening, are we? Talk about the weather and cheese things and what we've

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seen on the telly? Might as well critique the shape and consistency of human turds as talk about what's good on the telly.

MONA: (weepy) Spoilsport. Sad sack. Gloomy boots. Party pooper.

JEREMY: You know we're all going to croak someday. All freeze.

SARAH: (out front, spookily) It was almost as if he'd had a premonition about his own death. All unfreeze.

JEREMY: I could be a corpse on this carpet in a moment-beautiful carpet, by the way- and I'm supposed to discuss the bloody cheese things?

MONA: Stop it, Jerry, stop it, stop it! I hate it when you get morbid like this!

JEREMY: My God, does none of us read? Does none of us think? Does none of us have anything at all of substance to say? Look at us. None of us is living a life worth living. We're pathetic toothy boring creatures with ridiculous accents. We're a lot of rotting corpses is what we are. Isn't that the terrible horrible awful truth?

MONA: Stop it, Jerry, stop it! You're drunk!

SARAH: (throwing her drink in Jeremy s face) Damn you!

ROGER: (throwing his drink in Jeremy's face) Damn you, Jeremy ! Sir, you're a cad!

SARAH: Just then, the clock started to strike. The lights went out. And on the final stroke of seven. . . We hear three shots. Jeremy falls to the floor. Bang, bang, bang. Three shots. Probably from a Webley 45. Just a guess. Then somebody screamed. I think it may have been me. She screams.Yes, it was me. And when the lights came up. Lights back up to full. Jeremy was lying in missionary position on my carpet.

MONA: I can't believe that such a brief short while ago he was so alive, he was so terribly, terribly alive . . . I'm sorry, did I say that already?

DEXTER: If what you say is true, Mrs. Penworthy-Pilks, then the murder weapon is still in this room.

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ROGER, **SARAH**, **MONA:** [Horrified intake of breath.]

DEXTER: Indeed, the fatal pistol is still in someone's pocket. All three reach for their pockets and look about suspiciously. It's not as if any of you lacked motive. Why, even the furniture wanted him dead.

MONA: But we didn't want him dead. We loved Jeremy. He was so charming, so fun, so . . .

SARAH: So priapic.

MONA: Priapic. What's priapic?

SARAH: [Spreads her hands apart to show the size if Jeremy's sexual endowment.] So priapic.

DEXTER: Well I'm going to have the truth. Excuse me. The trooth.

ROGER: Inspector. I have a confession to make.

DEXTER: What sort of confession?

ROGER: Well, I don't much believe much in God much anymore. . .Anyway, now that I'm confessing I might as well say I don't really like the cheese things very much either. (high drama) I can say that now. I never much liked the cheese things very much, though I always said they were scrumptious. The trooth of it is, I was lying.

DEXTER: Must we discuss the bloody cheese things?

MONA: Jerry said exactly the same thing, just before he was riddled with hot lead.

ROGER: In any case, Inspector, you can take me away-for it was I who ventilated Jeremy's ventricles.

SARAH, **MONA**, **DEXTER:** [Horrified intake of breath.]

ROGER: (takes out a small pistol.) I ended his life with this starting pistol

SARAH, **MONA**, **DEXTER:** [Horrified intake if breath.]

ROGER: Which I stole from my public school when I was 12.

SARAH, **MONA**, **DEXTER:** [Horrified intake of breath.]

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ROGER: It's very hard to say all this as a disbelieving Christian because now I'm going to be hanged and I'll go into eternal empty void nothingness forever and ever instead of paradise-a nice place I always pictured rather like Brighton but without the tourists. Anyway I loved Jerry in some. . . squishy way. . . Did I say that already? But I couldn't stand it when he threw me over for the sofa, especially since I so badly desired that sofa yourself. Then when I found Jeremy'd had my green leather wingchair it was too, too much. My God, he had a passion for things!

SARAH: Just one moment, Inspector. As a partially disbelieving Christian I cannot allow this to happen. It was not only Roger with the starting pistol who killed Jeremy, it was I-with this Webley 45. Lifts her skirt and shows a gun strapped to her leg. Dexter whistles, Mona howls, and Roger barks like a dog. Thank you. Anyway I'm willing to face my Maker-if there really is one. My true punishment is to've killed the only man I ever loved.

MONA: Stop, Inspector! It was not only Sarah with the Webley and Roger with the starting pistol. It was I, with this .505 telescopic elephant hunting rifle. She takes an enormous hunting rifle from behind the couch. I shot him in conspiracy with the sofa, who hid the weapon for me. I don't need to tell you why I killed him. It was the sardine sandwiches he had for breakfast.[Jeremy jumps to his feet.]

JEREMY: I say, chaps, is dinner on yet? I'm sorry. Was I copulating with the rug again? Oh dear, I say, I seem to've been shot.

ROGER: Yes, Jerry, I'm afraid there's been a bit of a . . . shuuting ekcident.

JEREMY: Oh, a shuuting ekcident. Well the bullets seem to've ventilated but not violated my ventricles. (To Dexter) Who're you?

DEXTER: Larry Dexter of the Yard, sir.

JEREMY: I say, haven't we slept together?

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DEXTER: That would be two years ago last April, sir. Oh, yes. The butterscotch pudding. But if you're not dead, sir, I have to say my purpose in life is quite evaporated. (weeps) I've been rendered redundant.

JEREMY: In any case, chaps, I apologize for being so utterly beastly before the. . . Shuuting ekcident. All that morbid rot about death and corpses. But you see, some weeks ago I had a dramatic personal revelation. Because my doctor told me I had this. . . I had this . . . I had this ingrown toenail. I'd quite given up on life, you see. The bally thing made me so damned bitter and nihilistic.

MONA: Jerry, you never told me about your toenail!

JEREMY: I wanted to spare you, darling. The funny thing is, as I was lying there ventilated on the carpet I actually crossed over to the other side and I saw God, you see.

SARAH: You saw God? My theological doubts are dissipated!

JEREMY: God suggested I start appreciating things and stop copulating with them. Mostly I realize now how much I love you all-well I have loved you all haven't I, in quite a variety of ways. I mean the hammock was brilliant!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier – Humorous Interp

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